

Researchers Uncover a Bathhouse Complex in Ancient Pompeii

Archeological research has uncovered another treasure of the ancient Roman city of Pompeii: a large private bathhouse.

The explosion of Mount Vesuvius in 70 AD buried Pompeii in thick ash, wreckage, and lava, or hot liquid rock. Archeologists are continuing to find remains of the city under the ground.

The bathhouse was part of a large private house, the scientists said. The bathhouse holds a series of rooms that would have provided hot, warm, or cold conditions. The art and design of the complex, including mosaic works, also suggest the owner was wealthy.

“We have here perhaps the largest thermal complex in a private house in Pompeii,” said Gabriel Zuchtriegel, director of the Pompeii Archaeological Park.

He explained that Pompeii’s powerful and wealthy set up large spaces at their homes to hold major gatherings for ceremonies and other purposes.

“It was an opportunity to show the wealth in which they lived and also to have a nice thermal treatment,” he said.

A picture released by the Pompeii Archeological Park Press Office, Friday, January 17, 2025, showing a private bathhouse recently discovered in the Pompeii archeological site.
(Archeological Park of Pompeii Press Office Via AP, HO)

The baths were unearthed in the so-called Regio IX, a large central area of Pompeii Park that is still unexplored.

Recently, archeologists working in the same area found a bakery, a laundry and two homes. They also found the bones of three people who died in the volcanic burst.

Pompeii was not the only city destroyed in the explosion. It also buried the city of Herculaneum.

Zuchtriegel said wealthy citizens of Pompeii often would first take a bath and then attend a banquet, or a big meal. The private thermal complex permitted them to do so together at the home where the banquet was held.

“There is room for about 30 people who could do the whole routine, and that could also be done in public baths. So there is the caldarium, a very warm environment, and also a large tub with cold water,” he said.

I'm Caty Weaver.

The Associated Press reported this story. Caty Weaver adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

bathhouse - n. อาคารที่มีอุปกรณ์สำหรับการอาบน้ำ

mosaic - n. การตกแต่งผนังที่ทำจากชิ้นส่วนเล็กๆ จำนวนมากและแสดงภาพหรือลวดลาย

thermal - adj. เกี่ยวกับ ความร้อน หรือเกิดจากความร้อน

opportunity - n. โอกาสที่เอื้ออำนวยจากสถานการณ์ เวลา และสถานที่

bakery - n. สถานที่สำหรับอบหรือขายขนมอบ

laundry - n. ธุรกิจที่ซักเสื้อผ้าหรือผ้าปูที่นอน

routine - n. วิธีการทำสิ่งใดสิ่งหนึ่งที่เป็นมาตรฐานหรือทำเป็นประจำ

tub - n. ภาชนะทรงกลมขนาดใหญ่ที่ใหญ่พอสำหรับซักเสื้อผ้าหรืออาบน้ำ

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What significant discovery has archaeological research recently made in the ancient Roman city of Pompeii?

- A. A public amphitheater
- B. A large private bathhouse
- C. A new market square
- D. A temple dedicated to a new god

2. What natural disaster caused the burial of Pompeii in 70 AD?

- A. An earthquake
- B. A massive flood
- C. The eruption of Mount Vesuvius
- D. A severe sandstorm

3. Which of the following materials is NOT mentioned as having buried Pompeii?

- A. Thick ash
- B. Wreckage
- C. Hot liquid rock
- D. Large boulders

4. According to the article, what indicated the wealth of the bathhouse owner?

- A. The sheer size of the private house it was part of.
- B. The number of servants employed in the bathhouse.
- C. The art and design of the complex, including mosaic works.
- D. The exotic perfumes used in the various rooms.

5. What range of bathing conditions did the newly discovered bathhouse offer its users?

- A. Only hot conditions
- B. Only cold conditions
- C. Hot, warm, and cold conditions
- D. Warm and cool conditions only

6. Who is Gabriel Zuchtriegel in relation to the Pompeii Archaeological Park?

- A. A lead archeologist
- B. A historian
- C. The director
- D. A chief financier

7. What is the significance of the discovered bathhouse, according to Gabriel Zuchtriegel?

- A. It is the oldest known bathhouse in Pompeii.
- B. It is possibly the largest thermal complex in a private house in Pompeii.
- C. It is the only private bathhouse ever found in Pompeii.
- D. It features unique architectural styles previously unseen.

8. For what primary purpose did Pompeii's powerful and wealthy set up large spaces in their homes?

- A. To store their valuable goods.
- B. To house their extensive libraries.
- C. To hold major gatherings for ceremonies and other purposes.
- D. To grow exotic plants and herbs.

9. Besides providing thermal treatment, what other advantage did these large spaces offer to the wealthy, as mentioned by Zuchtriegel?

- A. An opportunity to train gladiators.
- B. A chance to display their wealth.
- C. A venue for public political debates.
- D. A place for solitary meditation.

10. When was the picture of the recently discovered private bathhouse released by the Pompeii Archeological Park Press Office?

- A. Friday, January 17, 2024
- B. Friday, January 17, 2025
- C. Thursday, February 17, 2025
- D. Friday, January 10, 2025

11. The newly unearthed baths were found in which specific area of Pompeii Park?

- A. The Forum
- B. The Necropolis
- C. Regio IX
- D. Via dell'Abbondanza

12. What characteristic is attributed to Regio IX in the article?

- A. It is the most densely populated area.
- B. It is a large central area that is still unexplored.
- C. It is known for its public monuments.
- D. It was the primary residential area for common citizens.

13. Besides the bathhouse, what other structures did archeologists recently discover in the same Regio IX area?

- A. A temple, a school, and a theater.
- B. A stadium, an arena, and public gardens.
- C. A bakery, a laundry, and two homes.
- D. A courthouse, a prison, and a treasury.

14. What human remains were also found by archeologists in the Regio IX area?

- A. The bones of several children.
- B. The skeleton of a single warrior.
- C. The bones of three people who died in the volcanic burst.
- D. Ancient tombs with well-preserved mummies.

15. Apart from Pompeii, which other city was also destroyed by the same volcanic explosion?

- A. Ostia
- B. Rome
- C. Herculaneum

D. Naples